THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER TWENTY

“ASSEMBLE”

July 23, 2014 – May 5, 2015
San Diego • Hollywood • Los Feliz • Fifth Avenue

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

PROLOGUE: THE ONLY SECRET

INT. AMOND AND HARMONY'S HOUSE - NURSERY - SILVER LAKE - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, JULY 23, 2014 - 3:10 A.M. PDT - THE NIGHT BEFORE COMIC-CON

A small nursery painted the soft green of the inside of a lime. Glow-in-the-dark stars on the ceiling. A crib. A rocking chair. In the rocking chair, AMOND BAKER (32), in boxer shorts and a Hulk T-shirt with spit-up on the shoulder, rocks LYRIC BAKER (3 months) against his chest.

She's finally asleep. He doesn't move. He barely breathes.

He shifts her carefully onto one arm. With his free hand, he digs into the pocket of the rocking chair's seat cushion and pulls out a small navy-blue ring box. He opens it with his thumb. A ring catches the starlight from the ceiling.

AMOND
(a whisper, to the baby)
Okay. Here's the plan. Saturday. Hall H. The Q and A. Six thousand five hundred people.

(beat)
I know. I KNOW. Daddy has never kept a secret in his whole life. Daddy told Entertainment Tonight how THE AVENGERS ended. Daddy is a sieve.

(beat)
But I have kept this one for forty-one days. I haven't told Uncle Marc. I haven't told Aunt Esther. I haven't told your Uncle Tyrese, and he's Captain America, he would understand.

Lyric sighs in her sleep and grabs a fistful of his T-shirt.

AMOND (CONT'D)
You're the only one who knows. So don't say anything. I know you can't talk yet. Don't start Saturday.

He closes the ring box. Holds his daughter. Rocks.

In the dark hallway outside, unseen, HARMONY DIVINE (32), in a robe, stands with a hand over her mouth, listening. She turns very quietly and goes back to bed. She'll pretend she didn't hear. Of course she heard.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, AUGUST 3, 2014, 9:20 AM PT

'GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY' ROCKETS TO $97.8M, BIGGEST AUGUST OPENING EVER; MARVEL'S 10TH STRAIGHT NO. 1 DEBUT

James Gunn's space opera, featuring a talking raccoon and a tree with a three-word vocabulary, defied industry skeptics. The film ends with a red Infinity Gem in the hands of the Nova Corps.

PART ONE: COMIC-CON 2014

INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - SERVICE STAIRWELL B - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, JULY 24, 2014 - 11:59 P.M. PDT - COMIC-CON, NIGHT ONE

The same concrete stairwell. GERALD WASHINGTON (62) in his folding chair. A thermos. A paperback. And taped to the wall above his chair, framed in cheap gold plastic: a wedding photo. Gerald and his wife, dancing at a reception last December, beside the bride and groom.

The fire door opens. MARC-ANTHONY (32) and ESTHER (31). Right on time.

GERALD
Mr. and Mrs. Bullock.

ESTHER
Ms. Smilley professionally. Mrs. Bullock in this stairwell.

GERALD
In this stairwell you're family. My wife wants you to know that dress still hasn't come off the hanger. She takes it out and looks at it on Sundays.

MARC-ANTHONY
(sitting on the step)
Gerald, something's wrong with Amond.

GERALD
Wrong how?

MARC-ANTHONY
He's quiet. He's been quiet for six weeks. He came over for Lyric's three-month birthday barbecue and he didn't tell me a single thing about his life. Not one. He told me he liked the potato salad. That was the whole conversation.

ESTHER
Something's going on with him. Harmony knows. She has that face.

GERALD
(sipping his coffee, very casual)
Huh.

MARC-ANTHONY
(narrowing his eyes)
Gerald. Do you know something?

GERALD
I'm head of security for the Marriott Marquis during Comic-Con, Mr. Bullock. A gentleman asked me at nine o'clock tonight which door is closest to the Hall H stage left stairs and whether a person could get onstage from the floor in under fifteen seconds. I told him eleven, if he doesn't trip.

Marc-Anthony stares at him. Esther's mouth falls open.

ESTHER
No.

GERALD
I didn't say anything. I'm a door man. I keep doors shut.

MARC-ANTHONY
(standing up, astonished)
Amond Baker kept a secret from ME?!

ESTHER
Sit down. Sit DOWN. If you so much as look at him funny on Saturday, I'll put you through the wall.

CUT TO:

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - THE HALL H LINE - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2014 - 6:30 A.M. PDT

Dawn over the bay. GARY MORRIS (48), DR. PRIYA SHAH (29), DARNELL JOHNSON (36) and TOMMY RUIZ (26), on folding chairs, all four in matching homemade T-shirts with a red-eyed robot face: "HELLO, FATHER."

TOMMY
Real talk. Edgar Wright left ANT-MAN in May. The guy who made the first one. And now it's Peyton Reed?

DARNELL
"Creative differences." Same thing they said about Terrence Howard in '08 and everything turned out fine.

GARY
I'm not apologizing in advance for Peyton Reed. I'll wait for footage. I've grown.

PRIYA
You have not grown. You wrote "Peyton Reed - TBD" in the notebook this morning. I saw it.

GARY
That's not an apology. That's a placeholder. Apologies are permanent. Placeholders are science.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - THE MARVEL STUDIOS PANEL - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2014 - 4:55 P.M. PDT

Hall H at capacity. 6,500 people. KEVIN FEIGE (41) at center stage.

FEIGE
Next Friday, a raccoon and a tree are going to open in eight thousand theaters. Let's start small.

ANT-MAN. PEYTON REED (50) walks out with PAUL RUDD (45), Scott Lang, the reformed cat burglar. Rudd shows test footage: Scott, in prison orange, getting out of San Quentin. Then a lab in San Francisco. Hank Pym, older, haunted, behind a desk, holding out a battered helmet.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK PYM)
I made something terrible, Mr. Lang. I'm trying to make up for it by giving away something good.

The hall roars. In the front section, Gary takes out his notebook and crosses out "Peyton Reed - TBD."

GARY
(writing)
Two hundred and twenty. That's... an apology.

PRIYA
See? Growth.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 5:20 P.M. PDT

The lights drop. A single red light glows on the giant screen. A voice, calm and amused, slides out of the speakers. JAMES SPADER's voice.

ULTRON (V.O.)
When you build a child, you give it everything you are. Every gift. And every wound.

The lights snap on. On stage: a practical Ultron suit, eight feet tall, gleaming silver and red, worn by a stunt performer on stilts with James Spader's motion-capture rig. Every one of its sixty points of articulation is a working piece of real metal. It turns its head to the crowd.

The hall screams.

ULTRON (CONT'D)
(James Spader, from the stage)
Hello, San Diego. My father is late. My father is always late.

JOSS WHEDON (50) walks out with the whole cast of AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON. The most famous lineup in movies, one by one: Marc-Anthony. Esther. TYRESE AVERY (33), two days after his birthday. AMOND (32), weirdly pale. HARMONY

(32). DAVID TIPTON (33). ELXA BULLOCK (33). ARIANNA CUMMINGS (31), Claire Barton, Hawkeye. GRACE BULLOCK (20) and ELIJAH BLACKMAN (20), the Maximoff twins, together on a Hall H stage for the first time. And PAUL BETTANY (43), introduced simply as "the man who plays someone who hasn't been born yet."

The noise is unlike anything the hall has ever produced.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - THE FOOTAGE - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 5:31 P.M. PDT

The footage: Avengers Mansion at night, a party, glasses clinking. Then every light in the house goes red. A broken robot drags itself into the room, made of spare parts from Hank's lab. It speaks with Hank Pym's own voice, warped.

Hank Pym, in a tuxedo, his drink falling from his hand.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK PYM)
Ultron. You're not ready.

ULTRON (ON SCREEN)
No, Father. You weren't.

A flash of action. The Hulk against Iron Man's Extremis armor in a crowded city street. Wanda's eyes going red. A blur of white hair. A city in eastern Europe, Transia's capital, shot on real streets in Italy's Aosta Valley, as a swarm of Ultron sentries descends. And a final image: a red figure with a gold gem in its forehead, emerging from a cradle, opening its eyes.

Paul Bettany, on stage, gives a tiny, deadpan wave.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - Q AND A - LATER

SUPER: 5:52 P.M. PDT

The Q and A. A woman in a Scarlet Witch costume asks Grace how it feels to be "Wanda at last." Grace says it feels like being fourteen and getting her show back. Big applause.

A boy, about ten, asks Esther if Thor can beat Ultron. Esther says Thor can beat anything if she has a nap first. More applause.

Then the moderator points to the left microphone.

MODERATOR
Next question, go ahead.

A beat. Nobody steps up to the left mic. A murmur through the hall.

Onstage, Amond Baker stands up from his chair.

AMOND
(into his handheld mic, voice shaking)
Actually... I have a question. If that's okay. It's for Harmony.

Every head in Hall H turns. Harmony, three seats down, freezes. Marc-Anthony grips the arms of his chair so hard Esther grabs his wrist under the table.

ESTHER
(whisper)
Don't. You. Dare.

Amond walks across the stage. Past Tyrese. Past Elxa. Past the eight-foot practical Ultron, whose performer slowly turns its head to watch him go. Six thousand five hundred people go completely silent. Amond stops in front of Harmony's chair.

AMOND
Harmony. In 2009 you were the new girl in IRON MAN 2. You walked into the gym at the training facility, and I was on a rowing machine, and you told me I was "doing it wrong," and you were right. I've been doing everything wrong for five years.

(beat, laughter in the hall)
You said "just friends" for four years. I said "okay" every single time. And I meant it every time, because being your friend was the best thing that ever happened to me. Until April. Until her.

His voice breaks.

AMOND (CONT'D)
Everybody in this business says I can't keep a secret. I've kept this one for forty-three days. I didn't tell anybody. Not Marc. Not Esther. Not Tyrese. Not Gerald. Well, Gerald a little. I needed the stairs.

A ripple of laughter. In the wings, Gerald Washington is standing just offstage in his blazer with his arms crossed, beaming.

Amond gets down on one knee. The hall LOSES IT. He opens the box.

AMOND (CONT'D)
Harmony Divine. Will you marry me? In front of six thousand people who are going to tell everybody, which is fine, because I'm done keeping secrets. This was the last one.

Harmony looks at him. Then at the ring. She's laughing and crying at the same time.

HARMONY
(into her own mic, so everyone hears)
I heard you tell the baby. Wednesday. At three in the morning.

AMOND
(horrified)
You... you KNEW?!

HARMONY
I've known since Wednesday. I kept it for three whole days, and it almost killed me.

(beat, softly)
Yes. Obviously yes. Get up off that floor, baby, you're going to hurt your knee.

He slips the ring onto her finger. He stands. She pulls him into a kiss. Hall H explodes, the loudest sound ever recorded in the room, louder than Thor's entrance, louder than "Hello, Father."

Behind them, the eight-foot Ultron performer slowly starts clapping its enormous metal hands. CLANG. CLANG. CLANG.

Marc-Anthony is on his feet, his face in his hands.

MARC-ANTHONY
(into his mic, wrecked)
He kept a secret. From ME. Forty-three days. I've known this man since we were kids, and he couldn't keep a secret about a SANDWICH.

AMOND
(grinning, over Harmony's shoulder)
Nobody tells me anything, Marc. I figured I'd return the favor.

CUT TO:

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2014

#HulkProposes - Amond and Harmony - 43 Days - #AgeOfUltron - Hello San Diego - Ultron Clapping - Gerald

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

harmonydivine: he said yes. i mean i said yes. we both said yes. the robot clapped. 6:40 PM Jul 26th from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: 43 days. no one knew. not marc. NOT MARC. i am a vault. i am fort knox. i am a man of mystery. (harmony knew. she always knows) 6:52 PM Jul 26th from Twitter for iPhone

marcanthonyb: i need everyone to understand how betrayed and proud i am at the same time. it's a new feeling. i don't like it. i love it. @amondbaker 7:01 PM Jul 26th from Twitter for iPhone

SDMarriottGerald: it's 11 seconds from the side door to the stage if you don't trip. he didn't trip. 7:15 PM Jul 26th from Twitter for Android

ShellHead1963: i was in the third row. i cried at a superhero panel for the third straight year. Apology #221: In 2009 I said Black Widow and Hulk had "zero chemistry" in the Iron Man 2 set photos. 7:30 PM Jul 26th from Twitter for Android

PEOPLE.COM - SUNDAY, JULY 27, 2014

HULK PROPOSES TO BLACK WIDOW IN HALL H! AMOND BAKER AND HARMONY DIVINE ARE ENGAGED

The couple, who welcomed daughter Lyric on Easter Sunday, got engaged in front of 6,500 fans at Comic-Con. "He kept it from his best friend for 43 days," says one person on the stage. "In our group, that's a world record."

DEADLINE.COM - TUESDAY, OCTOBER 28, 2014, 1:30 PM PT

MARVEL UNVEILS PHASE THREE AT EL CAPITAN: 'CIVIL WAR,' 'DOCTOR STRANGE,' 'BLACK PANTHER' WITH CHADWICK BOSEMAN, 'CAPTAIN MARVEL,' TWO-PART 'INFINITY WAR'

"Captain America: Civil War" will put Tyrese Avery's Steve Rogers against Marc-Anthony Bullock's Tony Stark on May 6, 2016. "We did the math," Kevin Feige told the crowd. "No S.H.I.E.L.D. plus a house on Fifth Avenue equals a custody fight."

PART TWO: THE PREMIERE

EXT. DOLBY THEATRE - HOLLYWOOD AND HIGHLAND - EVENING

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 13, 2015 - 5:10 P.M. PDT - WORLD PREMIERE OF "AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON"

The home of the Oscars, wrapped in red and silver. A sixty-foot banner of the full team. In the forecourt, the eight-foot practical Ultron from Comic-Con stands on a pedestal, behind velvet ropes, surrounded by a crowd of children having their picture taken with it.

Fans by the thousand. Iron Men. Thors. Kooky Quartet cosplay groups of four: Cap, Hawkeye, Scarlet Witch, Quicksilver. A sign held up by a teenage girl: "GRACE BULLOCK HAPPY 21ST BIRTHDAY (YESTERDAY)."

EXT. DOLBY THEATRE - RED CARPET - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 5:24 P.M. PDT

GRACE BULLOCK (21), in a scarlet dress with a high collar, sees the sign. She runs straight over and hugs the girl over the barricade. ELIJAH BLACKMAN (21), in a white suit that matches Pietro's hair, chases after her.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD REPORTER
Grace! Happy birthday! A year ago, you were in a cell in the Winter Soldier credits. Tonight you're an Avenger. How does it feel?

GRACE
Like the bad luck finally wore off.

ELIJAH
I've got nothing that cool to say. I run fast. I'm very excited.

Further down the carpet: AMOND (33) and HARMONY (32), engaged, the ring on her finger every photographer's target. Harmony carries LYRIC (11 months), in a tiny Black Widow onesie, wearing noise-canceling baby earmuffs. Lyric waves at the photographers. Two hundred cameras explode.

E! REPORTER
Amond! Harmony! Wedding date?

AMOND
This year. That's all I'm saying.

(beat)
No. Wait. I'm done with secrets. September nineteenth. Malibu. Bring a sweater, it's on the beach.

HARMONY
(closing her eyes)
Amond.

AMOND
I'm open now, Harmony. I'm an open book.

HARMONY
Open books get their weddings swarmed by helicopters.

AMOND
(to the camera, immediately)
It's October. In Ohio. On a foggy lake.

CUT TO:

EXT. DOLBY THEATRE - RED CARPET - LATER

SUPER: 5:41 P.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony (33) and Esther (32) walk the carpet holding hands. Behind them, by a careful arrangement with the publicists, the two families walk the carpet together for the first time. VICTOR DONOHUE (78) and JOAN (76). NATASHA (53) and ROBERT (56). And beside them, DESMOND SMILLEY (57) and CELESTE (55), and CORNELIUS SMILLEY (81) with HATTIE (79).

Two great Black Hollywood dynasties on one red carpet. The press line goes dead quiet, then starts shouting all at once.

VARIETY REPORTER
Mr. Donohue! Mr. Smilley! The two of you together on a red carpet for the first time in almost fifty years. What changed?

Victor and Cornelius look at each other. Two old men, each leaning on a cane.

CORNELIUS
Twin girls who call us both "Pop-Pop" and can't tell us apart from behind.

VICTOR
(dry)
It's the canes. We have the same cane.

The press line laughs. Cornelius actually smiles.

CUT TO:

INT. DOLBY THEATRE - BACKSTAGE CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:15 P.M. PDT

A narrow service corridor. Kevin Feige (41) is pacing with Joss Whedon (50). Marc-Anthony comes around the corner, catches Feige's eye, and points at him.

MARC-ANTHONY
Kevin. You've hidden every post-credits scene from me since 2012. I found out about Thanos with the rest of America. I'm in this movie. I'm Iron Man. Tell me what the stinger is.

FEIGE
No.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'll do the Cameo Clause bit on GOOD MORNING AMERICA. Again.

FEIGE
You'll do it anyway.

MARC-ANTHONY
(to Whedon)
Joss. You love me. Tell me one thing. One word.

WHEDON
(thinking about it)
...Five.

MARC-ANTHONY
Five? Five what?

Whedon and Feige walk away. Marc-Anthony is left alone in the corridor.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(to the empty hallway)
FIVE WHAT?!

CUT TO:

INT. DOLBY THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE FILM - NIGHT

SUPER: 7:12 P.M. PDT

The film plays. A montage, intercut with 3,400 people.

ON SCREEN: Transia. Snow. Every Avenger, in a single unbroken shot, storming the HYDRA fortress on Wundagore Mountain: Thor's lightning, Cap's shield, Hawkeye's arrows, Janet shrinking through a gun slit, Hank growing to sixty feet as Giant-Man and lifting a tank, Iron Man's armor flowing over his skin mid-flight. The twins escape in the chaos.

ON SCREEN: The party at Avengers Mansion. Ultron's first awakening, built in Hank's lab from Hank's own brain patterns and Tony's combat logs. It drags itself into the room, a heap of scrap.

ULTRON (ON SCREEN)
Hank. Father. You gave me your mind. Did you think I wouldn't notice how much you hate yourself?

IN THE AUDIENCE: A shiver goes through the room. David Tipton, in the fourth row, closes his eyes.

ON SCREEN: Johannesburg. Wanda twists the Hulk's mind, and Iron Man's Hulkbuster armor drops out of the sky in pieces, assembling around him in midair. A real ten-story building, scheduled for demolition, comes down around them. Amond in motion capture and Marc-Anthony in the practical Hulkbuster suit actually traded blows on set.

ON SCREEN: The Vision. Ultron builds him in a cradle in Seoul: synthetic flesh, a gem in his forehead, the brain patterns of a man named SIMON WILLIAMS, the Wonder Man of the comics. The Vision turns on his creator. Then, in a quiet scene with Wanda in a ruined church, he touches his own cheek and finds it wet.

PAUL BETTANY (ON SCREEN, AS VISION)
I am crying. I was not built to cry.

GRACE (ON SCREEN, AS WANDA)
Nobody is.

IN THE AUDIENCE: A loud, collective "OHHHH" from the comic fans. Somebody in the balcony yells, "AVENGERS #58! EVEN AN ANDROID CAN CRY!"

ON SCREEN: The climax. Transia's capital, under a sky full of Ultron sentries. The twins have turned against Ultron, fighting for their homeland. Pietro, a white blur, carries forty-one children out of a collapsing school in one second. Hawkeye, Claire Barton, on a rooftop alone with a quiver of trick arrows, holds a street against two hundred robots.

ARIANNA (ON SCREEN, AS CLAIRE BARTON)
(to Pietro, firing)
Hey, kid. You're fast. I'm good. Let's see which matters more.

IN THE AUDIENCE: A roar. Arianna Cummings, in the sixth row, waves.

ON SCREEN: Ultron's final body, the Vision holding him in the burning ruins of a Transian church. Ultron, cracked, speaking softly to the son he made.

ULTRON (ON SCREEN)
My father made me in his image. I made you in mine. We'll see who disappoints whom.

PAUL BETTANY (ON SCREEN, AS VISION)
I imagine we both will. That is what being alive means.

The Vision closes his hand. Ultron is gone. Somewhere across the world, in the dark, a single red light goes out on a dozen shelves of spare parts. One stays lit.

CUT TO:

INT. DOLBY THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE WEDDING - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:24 P.M. PDT

ON SCREEN: Avengers Mansion, weeks later. The house is half repaired. Hank Pym has been missing for nineteen days. Janet van Dyne sits alone in his destroyed lab, holding his shattered Ant-Man helmet.

The door opens. A man walks in, in a yellow-and-black costume with antennae on the helmet and a pair of stingers on his wrists. Yellowjacket. He moves differently from Hank. Swaggers. Talks loud.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS YELLOWJACKET)
Pym's gone, sugar. I got rid of him. Name's Yellowjacket. And I'm a whole lot more fun.

IN THE AUDIENCE: A huge gasp. Comic fans know exactly what this is.

ON SCREEN: Janet stands up slowly. She looks at him a long time. She knows those eyes. She's known them since she was twenty years old.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
Is that right. You got rid of Hank Pym.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS YELLOWJACKET)
Gone for good.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
(stepping right up to him)
Then I guess you'll have to marry me instead.

IN THE AUDIENCE: Laughter and screaming at the same time. Elxa, in the fourth row, is getting hugged by everyone around her.

ON SCREEN: The mansion's garden, the next morning. White chairs on the lawn. Paper lanterns. Every Avenger in their best clothes. Thor, in full Asgardian ceremonial armor, officiates. Tony Stark is the best man. Janet walks down the aisle in a gown she designed herself, gold and white, with a tiny wasp brooch at the shoulder. Waiting at the end of the aisle: Yellowjacket, helmet under his arm, shaking.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
Do you, Yellowjacket, who have never existed before last Tuesday, take this woman...

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS YELLOWJACKET)
(his swagger cracking, his voice small)
I do.

(beat)
Jan. I don't know who I am anymore.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
(taking both his hands)
That's okay. I do. I've always known. You're the man who built a monster, and then spent every day afterward trying to deserve the people it nearly killed.

(softly)
Hi, Hank.

He breaks. He's crying. She's crying. Thor slams Mjolnir down on the grass and a clap of thunder rattles every window in Manhattan.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
By the authority of Asgard, and New York State, which I checked: you are wed!

IN THE AUDIENCE: The Dolby stands up and cheers like it's a real wedding. In the third row, Victor Donohue is wiping his eyes. Natasha is openly crying at her daughter on screen.

ON SCREEN: The reception. Hank, still in yellow, takes Tony aside and hands him the shattered Ant-Man helmet and a small locked case.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK PYM)
I'm done being small. I need to grow up. The suit should go to someone who has something to make up for. Someone who knows what a second chance is worth.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Got anyone in mind?

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK PYM)
There's a cat burglar in San Quentin. Electrical engineer. Got caught stealing back money from a company that robbed its customers. He gets out in July.

IN THE AUDIENCE: "SCOTT LANG!" from twenty directions at once. "ANT-MAN, JULY SEVENTEENTH!"

CUT TO:

INT. DOLBY THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE OLD ORDER CHANGETH - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:31 P.M. PDT

ON SCREEN: Dawn. The front steps of Avengers Mansion. The founders stand in a loose line on the steps, bags packed: Tony, Thor, Hank and Janet. Steve Rogers stands on the sidewalk below them.

TYRESE (ON SCREEN, AS STEVE)
All four of you. Same morning.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
The gems, Steve. The Reality Gem in the Collector's vault. The Power Gem on Xandar. And others, still hidden. Someone is gathering. I have seen it in my dreams. I must go home and find out who.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
And I just got married. To a man who needs to remember he's a good person before he goes back to work.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK PYM)
She's being nice. I need a doctor. A real one.

Steve looks at Tony.

TYRESE (ON SCREEN, AS STEVE)
And you?

Tony takes his time.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Hank built Ultron with my combat logs. Nobody asked permission. Nobody signed anything. There was no S.H.I.E.L.D. to say no, because you burned it down, and you were right to.

(beat)
But somebody has to make sure the next guy who builds a god in his garage needs a license first. I'm going to Washington, Cap.

A beat. Steve's face doesn't change. But something passes between them. The audience feels it.

IN THE AUDIENCE: A low "ooooh" spreads through the comic fans. Somebody whispers "Registration." Somebody else whispers "Civil War."

TYRESE (ON SCREEN, AS STEVE)
I hope you know what you're doing.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
I never know what I'm doing. That's what makes me fun.

(he holds out a hand)
The house is yours.

They shake. The founders walk down the steps one by one. Thor launches into the sky. Tony's armor flows over him and he's gone. Hank and Janet get into a cab, holding hands.

Steve walks up the steps alone. He opens the front door.

The great hall of Avengers Mansion. Waiting for him, standing in the morning light under the portraits of the founders:

CLAIRE BARTON, Hawkeye, leaning on her bow, chewing gum. WANDA MAXIMOFF, in red, her hands glowing faintly. PIETRO MAXIMOFF, unable to stand still, bouncing on his heels.

Four of them. An old soldier, a carnival archer and two refugees from Transia.

ARIANNA (ON SCREEN, AS CLAIRE)
So. This is the team?

ELIJAH (ON SCREEN, AS PIETRO)
It's a small team.

GRACE (ON SCREEN, AS WANDA)
It's an odd team.

TYRESE (ON SCREEN, AS STEVE)
(a slow smile)
In my day we'd have called it kooky.

He lifts his shield. The three of them straighten.

TYRESE (ON SCREEN, AS STEVE) (CONT'D)
Avengers.

(beat)
Assemble.

SMASH TO BLACK.

IN THE AUDIENCE: The Dolby comes apart. Thirty-four hundred people on their feet. "HE SAID IT! HE SAID IT!" Tyrese, in the second row, has his head bowed, his hands over his face. Arianna, Grace and Elijah are in a pile hugging. Behind them, Esther leans over to Marc-Anthony.

ESTHER
(over the noise)
You're leaving the Avengers.

MARC-ANTHONY
(shell-shocked by the reaction)
Tony's leaving the Avengers. I'm just a guy in a nice suit.

ESTHER
Look around you, baby. Half this room thinks you're the bad guy now.

He looks around. A woman two rows back is glaring at him and mouthing "WASHINGTON?!" with genuine betrayal.

CUT TO:

INT. DOLBY THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE POST-CREDITS SCENE - LATER

SUPER: 9:43 P.M. PDT

The credits roll. Nobody leaves. And then:

ON SCREEN: KNOWHERE. The mining colony inside the severed head of a dead Celestial. But something is wrong. Fire on every level. Alarms. Bodies in the streets.

Inside THE COLLECTOR's museum: the glass cases are shattered. Creatures from a hundred worlds are loose, fleeing. Smoke everywhere. The Collector (Benicio del Toro) is on his knees in the middle of the floor, his white hair singed, blood on his fur coat.

A massive shadow fills the doorway. Heavy footsteps. Each one shakes the floor.

THE COLLECTOR (ON SCREEN)
(terrified, babbling)
Lord Thanos. I was keeping it for you. You must believe me. Safe. Very, very safe. We had an arrangement...

THANOS (JOSH BROLIN) steps out of the smoke. Purple skin. Gold armor. Nine feet tall. On his left hand: the golden Infinity Gauntlet. Six empty settings.

And beside him, silent, pale, a hooded figure in black, her skeletal face just visible: MISTRESS DEATH.

JOSH BROLIN (ON SCREEN, AS THANOS)
We had an arrangement, Taneleer. You would hold it until I was ready. Then you began to sell tickets.

He holds out his hand. The Collector, trembling, opens a small iron case. The yellow Reality Gem glows inside.

Thanos takes it between two enormous fingers. He looks at it the way a man looks at a ring he's about to give a woman.

JOSH BROLIN (ON SCREEN, AS THANOS) (CONT'D)
I sent a god. He failed. I sent Ronan. He failed. My errand boys have cost me years.

IN THE AUDIENCE: A murmur. "He's going himself. He's going HIMSELF." A man in the balcony is standing on his seat.

ON SCREEN: Thanos presses the Reality Gem into the first setting of the Gauntlet. A blinding yellow light. The museum walls ripple and twist, reality bending around his fist. The Collector screams. When the light fades, the Collector is simply gone. Not dead. Not anywhere. Erased.

Thanos turns to Death. Her hollow eyes look at the Gauntlet. At the single glowing gem.

JOSH BROLIN (ON SCREEN, AS THANOS) (CONT'D)
(quietly, almost tender)
One, my love.

(beat)
Five.

He closes his fist. The camera pushes in on the Gauntlet. One gem lit. Five dark sockets.

SMASH TO BLACK.

Title card: "THANOS WILL RETURN."

IN THE AUDIENCE: Silence. One full second of total, horrified silence. Then a sound like a stadium collapsing.

Marc-Anthony grabs Esther's arm.

MARC-ANTHONY
FIVE! JOSS SAID FIVE! THAT'S WHAT HE MEANT! HE GAVE ME THE LAST WORD OF THE MOVIE IN A HALLWAY!

ESTHER
(also yelling)
HE ERASED THE COLLECTOR!

MARC-ANTHONY
HE ERASED THE COLLECTOR WITH HIS HAND!

Down the row, Amond is holding a sleeping Lyric, the baby's earmuffs firmly in place, perfectly still in the middle of the roar.

AMOND
(to Harmony, whispering, stunned)
He erased him. With one gem. One. What does he do with six?

HARMONY
You didn't know?

AMOND
NOBODY TELLS ME ANYTHING.

HARMONY
(kissing his cheek)
Nobody told any of us this time, baby. Look around.

He looks. Every single Avenger in the row is screaming at the screen like a fan.

CUT TO:

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE - MONDAY, APRIL 13, 2015

gracebullock: my 21st birthday was yesterday. tonight i said "it's an odd team" in a movie and then cap said ASSEMBLE and then thanos erased a man. i'm going to bed for a year 11:40 PM Apr 13th from Twitter for iPhone

arianna_cummings: a carnival archer and three kooks. we're the avengers now. i'm still processing 11:52 PM Apr 13th from Twitter for iPhone

marcanthonyb: joss whedon told me the last word of the movie in a hallway at 6:15 tonight and i didn't understand it. i'm a genius billionaire playboy on screen. off screen i'm a man who didn't get the hint 12:05 AM Apr 14th from Twitter for iPhone

elxabullock: i got married in an avengers movie and my husband was dressed as a bee. a dream come true 12:20 AM Apr 14th from Twitter for iPhone

PART THREE: THE WORLD SEES IT

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, APRIL 26, 2015, 9:10 AM PT

'AGE OF ULTRON' LAUNCHES WITH $211.8M OVERSEAS, A WEEK BEFORE U.S. RELEASE; AUDIENCES IN 44 MARKETS BUZZING OVER "THE ENDING" AND "THE STINGER"

Exhibitors report that audiences are staying in their seats through the entire credits, and that the film's final 15 minutes, a wedding, the departure of four founding Avengers and the formation of a new lineup, have generated as much online discussion as the post-credits scene.

REDDIT.COM - r/marvelstudios - "[INTERNATIONAL SPOILERS] AGE OF ULTRON - THE ENDING AND THE STINGER" - 41,880 comments

u/WaspWings1963 (London, Apr 22, 11:30 PM BST)
THEY DID AVENGERS #59-60. Yellowjacket "killing" Hank Pym and Janet marrying him knowing it's Hank. 1968! I never thought I'd see it. And they did it WITHOUT the abuse storyline. Hank gets HELP. Hank goes to a DOCTOR. That's the version of Hank the comics took 30 years to get to.

u/KookyQuartetFan (Sydney, Apr 23, 1:10 AM AEST)
"In my day we'd have called it kooky." I'm 64 years old. I bought AVENGERS #16 off a spinner rack in 1965. Cap, Hawkeye, Quicksilver and the Scarlet Witch. I've waited fifty years. I sobbed.

u/RegistrationIsComing (Toronto, Apr 23, 7:45 PM EDT)
"Somebody has to make sure the next guy who builds a god in his garage needs a license first. I'm going to Washington, Cap." That's it. That's the Superhuman Registration Act. Tony's on the PRO side. CIVIL WAR is May 2016 and Tony just picked his side in an Ultron movie.

u/MadTitanFan (Sao Paulo, Apr 24, 2:20 AM BRT)
"My errand boys have cost me years." Loki in 2012. Ronan in Guardians. Thanos ran both of them. And now he's done with errand boys. He's coming himself. That's Infinity Gauntlet #1 energy.

u/GemCollector (Seoul, Apr 24, 4:00 PM KST)
The Collector didn't die. He was ERASED. By reality itself. One gem and Thanos can delete a person. ONE. Imagine six.

YOUTUBE.COM - "AGE OF ULTRON POST CREDITS REACTION - MEXICO CITY (THANOS ERASES THE COLLECTOR!!!)" - uploaded by marvel_mx - 13,664,019 views in 6 days

Description: el cine entero se quedó callado por un segundo y luego explotó. 0:38 "one, my love." 0:52 "five." 0:53 the man next to me fell out of his chair. literally. he's okay.

EXT. AMC UNIVERSAL CITYWALK 19 WITH IMAX - LINE - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 30, 2015 - 6:15 P.M. PDT - FIRST NORTH AMERICAN SHOWS

The four friends, the same spot. GARY (49), PRIYA (30), DARNELL (37), TOMMY (27). Tommy is on his third spoiler blackout, sleep mask and all. Priya has a newborn-sized gift bag.

DARNELL
What's that?

PRIYA
It's a onesie for Lyric. A tiny Kooky Quartet onesie. I made it. I'm going to mail it to Amond's agent.

GARY
How do you know it's the Kooky Quartet?

PRIYA
Because I've read every international thread for eight days with one eye closed so I don't see the stinger. The ending's everywhere, Gary. I know the ending. I don't know the stinger.

TOMMY
(through his sleep mask)
I don't know ANYTHING. Don't tell me the ending either.

DARNELL
Tommy, you're thirty feet from a forty-foot standee of the Kooky Quartet.

TOMMY
I'M NOT LOOKING AT IT.

CUT TO:

INT. AMC UNIVERSAL CITYWALK - IMAX AUDITORIUM - LATER

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 30, 2015 - 9:41 P.M. PDT

On screen: Thanos. "One, my love." The yellow gem. The Gauntlet. "Five."

Smash to black. The silence. Then three hundred people go off like a bomb.

Gary sits in his seat, absolutely still, his notebook open in his lap.

PRIYA
Gary? Gary, are you okay?

GARY
(very quietly)
In 2012, when they showed us Thanos at the end of THE AVENGERS, I wrote apology two-thirteen and said I believed every second. I lied a little. Part of me still thought he was a tease. That they'd never actually do the Gauntlet.

(beat)
It's been three years. He erased the Collector. He's going to do the whole thing. Infinity Gauntlet. All of it.

He writes something in the notebook. Underlines it twice. Closes it.

TOMMY
Two-twenty-two?

GARY
No. That's not an apology.

(beat)
That's a pledge. "I will never doubt this company again."

DARNELL
You'll doubt them next year.

GARY
I'll doubt them next WEEK. But I'll feel bad about it.

CUT TO:

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - FRIDAY, MAY 1, 2015

#AgeOfUltron - One My Love - The Collector - Kooky Quartet - Yellowjacket - #TeamCap - #TeamIronMan - Tony Is Going To Washington - Even An Android Can Cry

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "AGE OF ULTRON - THE ENDING (SPOILERS)" (Page 1 of 1,671)

priya_shah_phd (May 1, 12:40 AM)
Let's talk about the end. Four founders leave. Tony goes to Washington. The new lineup is a 96-year-old soldier, a circus archer and two Transian mutants nobody trusts. That's the comics. That's 1965 exactly. And it's the setup for the most painful story in Marvel history, because next year Tony's going to come back with a law, and Cap's going to be the guy who says no.

DarnellDoesComics (May 1, 12:58 AM)
Hank's arc. He made a murderer out of his own brain and literally lost his identity, and his wife married him anyway and said "Hi, Hank." Then he gave up the Ant-Man suit to a guy in prison. That's the best character arc in this whole universe and nobody's talking about it because of the purple guy.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (May 1, 1:10 AM)
Everybody's talking about it, Darnell. #Yellowjacket is trending. There are people in my theater who didn't know Janet and Hank weren't married already who are now writing wedding fan fiction.

TommyTwoGuns (May 1, 1:30 AM)
i went in knowing NOTHING and i'm here to say: i am TEAM CAP. tony is going to WASHINGTON. how could he

ShellHead1963 (May 1, 1:44 AM)
I'm Team Iron Man. Hank built a killer robot in his garage and almost destroyed a country. Somebody HAS to sign something. Fight me, Tommy.

TommyTwoGuns (May 1, 1:45 AM)
gary it's 1:45 in the morning

ShellHead1963 (May 1, 1:45 AM)
FIGHT ME

PART FOUR: THE NUMBER

INT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - LOS FELIZ - MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 3, 2015 - 9:00 A.M. PDT

EMMA and VICTORIA BULLOCK (almost three) are at the kitchen table in matching Thor capes, eating cereal. Esther (32) makes coffee. Marc-Anthony (33) is reading the trades on his iPad at the counter with an expression of deep injury.

MARC-ANTHONY
"Bullock's Stark has become the MCU's first true antagonist from within the hero ranks." Antagonist! "Avengers fans are already selling hashtag Team Cap shirts outside theaters." There's a man on Hollywood Boulevard selling shirts with my face crossed out.

ESTHER
How much are they?

MARC-ANTHONY
Fifteen dollars.

ESTHER
That's a good price for a shirt.

Her phone buzzes. FEIGE. She puts him on speaker.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Friday, eighty-six point two, including twenty-eight point one from Thursday night. Saturday, sixty point four. Sunday, fifty-two. One hundred and ninety-eight point six million dollars domestic.

ESTHER
That's under the first one.

FEIGE (V.O.)
It's sixteen million under the biggest opening in history, which was also ours. It's the second-biggest opening of all time. Worldwide total, six hundred and forty-eight point three million dollars. In twelve days.

MARC-ANTHONY
Kevin. What are the exit polls saying about the ending?

FEIGE (V.O.)
(a pause)
Fifty-four percent of audiences under twenty-five say they're "Team Cap." Thirty-one percent say "Team Iron Man." Fifteen percent say "I don't know yet, and I'm scared."

MARC-ANTHONY
So I'm losing.

FEIGE (V.O.)
You're losing a fight that doesn't happen for a year. That's the best marketing campaign in the history of this company.

Victoria tugs on Marc-Anthony's sleeve.

VICTORIA
Daddy. Are you a bad guy?

The kitchen goes quiet. Esther turns around from the coffee pot.

Marc-Anthony picks his daughter up and sits her on the counter so they're eye to eye.

MARC-ANTHONY
No, baby. Tony's not a bad guy. Tony's scared. Something terrible happened, and Tony wants to make sure it never happens again.

VICTORIA
Is Uncle Tyrese scared?

MARC-ANTHONY
Uncle Tyrese is scared too. He's scared of something different.

(beat)
That's what makes it a hard fight. Nobody's wrong. Everybody's scared.

Victoria thinks about this very seriously.

VICTORIA
I'm Team Mommy.

Esther laughs so hard she has to put the coffee down.

ESTHER
Smartest person in this house.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, MAY 3, 2015, 9:30 AM PT

'AGE OF ULTRON' DEBUTS TO $198.6M, NO. 2 ALL-TIME BEHIND 'THE AVENGERS'; GLOBAL CUME $648.3M; CINEMASCORE A

Donohue's sequel delivered the second-biggest opening in history, behind its own predecessor's $214.6M. Exit polls show audiences split down the middle on the film's ending, with "Team Cap" and "Team Iron Man" merchandise already selling out a year ahead of "Captain America: Civil War."

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MONDAY, MAY 4, 2015

THE OLD ORDER CHANGETH: HOW 'AGE OF ULTRON' FIRED ITS OWN FOUNDERS, AND WHY AUDIENCES CHEERED

"The biggest franchise in the world just ended its biggest movie by benching Iron Man, Thor, Ant-Man and the Wasp, and handing the keys to a team whose most famous member is a 1940s soldier," says one rival studio executive. "Nobody in this town would have the nerve. Marvel did it, and audiences stood up and applauded."

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - (Issue of May 15, 2015)

THE WEDDING NOBODY SAW COMING

Elxa Bullock and David Tipton on Hank and Janet's Yellowjacket wedding, adapted from AVENGERS #60 (1969). "We didn't keep the darkness of the old comics," Bullock says. "We kept the love. Janet always knew who he was. In our version, he gets to find out too."

VARIETY - MONDAY, MAY 4, 2015

"ONE, MY LOVE": THANOS ERASES THE COLLECTOR AND TURNS 'INFINITY WAR' INTO A COUNTDOWN

Marvel's two-part finale is three years away, but the post-credits scene has already set the terms: one gem down, five to go, and a villain who has stopped sending others. Searches for "Infinity Gauntlet" rose 3,400% over the weekend.

EPILOGUE: TEAM MOMMY

EXT. AVENGERS MANSION SET - 890 FIFTH AVENUE (EXTERIOR LOCATION) - NEW YORK - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 4, 2015 - 11:30 P.M. EDT

The real townhouse on Fifth Avenue the production used for the Avengers Mansion exterior. The street is quiet, Central Park dark across the road. A brass plaque on the gate, the production's replica, left in place with the owner's permission: "THE AVENGERS."

Tyrese Avery (33) stands on the sidewalk in a hoodie, hands in his pockets, alone, looking at the plaque.

A car pulls up. Marc-Anthony (33) gets out, in a ball cap, two coffees.

TYRESE
You flew to New York.

MARC-ANTHONY
I had a GOOD MORNING AMERICA thing tomorrow. Also, I heard you were standing outside a house on Fifth Avenue at midnight, staring at it like Bucky.

He hands Tyrese a coffee. They stand side by side looking at the plaque.

TYRESE
There are people outside theaters selling T-shirts with your face crossed out.

MARC-ANTHONY
Fifteen dollars. Good price.

TYRESE
(beat)
I don't like it, man. Next year, I've got to look at you across an airport and mean it. Kids are going to pick sides. Families are going to pick sides. Twitter's already picking sides.

MARC-ANTHONY
That's the job.

TYRESE
I know it's the job. I just don't want them picking sides on US.

Marc-Anthony thinks about this. Then he takes out his phone, opens Twitter, and starts typing.

TYRESE (CONT'D)
What are you doing?

MARC-ANTHONY
Fixing it.

He shows Tyrese the screen. A photo he just took of the plaque, with a caption. Tyrese reads it, and laughs, and shakes his head.

TYRESE

Post it.

He posts it.

FADE OUT.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2015

marcanthonyb: [photo: the "THE AVENGERS" plaque on fifth avenue at midnight, two coffee cups on the gatepost] standing outside avengers mansion with captain america at midnight. we're on opposite teams next year. tonight we're on the same team. my daughter says she's team mommy. i'm team victoria. 12:02 AM May 5th from Twitter for iPhone

tyreseavery: @marcanthonyb team victoria. #CivilWar 12:04 AM May 5th from Twitter for iPhone

esthersmilley: @marcanthonyb @tyreseavery team mommy is undefeated 12:10 AM May 5th from Twitter for iPhone

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2015

#TeamVictoria - #TeamMommy - Avengers Mansion - #TeamCap - #TeamIronMan

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER TWENTY